What Economists Say They Study: Field Labels, JEL Codes, and the Measurement of Research

Bufan Jiang

Dong Fureng Institute of Economic and Social Development, Wuhan University

bufanjiang@uchicago.edu

November 2026

Abstract

Field labels are ubiquitous in economics: they appear on CVs, in JEL codes, in hiring and promotion files, and in the classifications that meta-analyses use to select studies. Yet the two main records of a scholar's field—the labels she declares and the codes attached to her articles—are rarely validated against each other. I assemble a hand-checked dataset of 273 tenured faculty in the top 20 US economics departments and compare CV-declared fields with the JEL codes recorded on their journal articles. Among the 181 professors who declare more than one field, 24.3% are full matches, 72.4% partial, and 3.3% no match; single-field professors are 90.3% full matches. The raw match rate falls from 71.0% at one JEL digit to 38.6% at three, but at three digits it is close to a uniform benchmark (36.8%). A within-professor benchmark, a permutation test, a mapping audit, and selection reweighting show that labels are informative but not a faithful summary of the portfolio. Field-label sampling and JEL-code sampling identify different populations, and the difference is largest for cross-cutting fields.

Keywords: field classification; JEL codes; research evaluation; meta-science; economics profession; measurement

JEL classification: A11, A14, B41, C81, I23, J44

1 Introduction

Meta-analysis and systematic review depend on classification. Before studies can be compared, they must be assigned to a field, a question, or a literature. In economics, two classification devices do most of this work: the field labels that scholars declare on CVs and homepages, and the JEL codes attached to articles. Both are used as if they described the same underlying object. This paper asks whether they do.

The question matters for the credibility of cumulative research. A meta-analysis that searches by JEL code and one that recruits authors by self-declared field will not see the same population; a department that evaluates fields using CV labels and one that uses publication codes will rank the same scholar differently. If the two records diverge systematically, then field-level statistics—specialization, diversity, the growth of fields, the supply of economists—inherit a measurement error that is neither random nor small.

Across the social sciences, scholars describe their expertise in terms that institutions use as measures of what they do. A CV lists research interests; hiring committees read the list as a map of a candidate's work; promotion letters treat self-described specialties as evidence of fit; science-policy analyses use field labels to measure specialization, diversity, and the diffusion of ideas. Yet a self-description and a publication record are different kinds of data. One is a claim about identity, audience, and aspiration; the other is a trace of what was published, where, and with whom. When the two diverge, the divergence is not simply noise to be averaged away. It is a measurement problem, and it matters wherever self-reports are used to evaluate scholars.

The problem is not specific to economics: medicine, education, and other fields also collect self-reports that are rarely validated against administrative records.

Economics is an unusually clean laboratory for studying this substitution. It has a public, hierarchical classification system (the JEL codes), public CVs and homepages, a small set of general-interest journals, and unusually strong field identities. The profession has long been interested in how economists are made (Klamer and Colander 1990; Colander 2005), and fields are the paradigms through which scholars see problems (Kuhn 1962). An economist who calls herself a labour economist is making a recognizable claim about the questions she asks, the seminars she attends, and the journals she reads (Akerlof and Kranton 2000). The JEL system then attaches labels to individual articles. This gives a rare opportunity to compare a scholar's self-description with an article-level record at the same level of granularity, and to ask whether the two records tell the same story.

Existing work documents differences in publication, hiring, and citation across fields (Card and DellaVigna 2013; Hamermesh 2013; Heckman and Moktan 2020), and a large meta-science literature examines reproducibility, publication bias, and the credibility of empirical claims (Christensen and Miguel 2018; Brodeur et al. 2020). The classification step itself has received little attention. Although this paper is not a survey in the usual sense, its subject is the classification infrastructure on which surveys and meta-analyses rely.

This paper asks a measurement question with direct consequences for meta-science: do economists' self-reported research interests match the publication records that meta-analysts and evaluators use to classify them? I answer it with a new dataset of 273 tenured faculty (Professors and Associate Professors) in the top 20 US economics departments. For each professor I take the research fields stated on the personal homepage or CV—hand-extracted and checked against the original source—and map each field to the JEL classification used by the American Economic Association (American Economic Association 2026). I then compare the declared field with the

professor's JEL-coded journal articles, using the code counts at the same level of granularity: one-digit fields against one-digit counts, two-digit fields against two-digit counts, and three-digit fields against three-digit counts. A declared field counts as matched if it ranks in the top three at its level.

Three results stand out. First, the gap is substantial, but its headline is driven by single-field professors: among the 181 professors who declare more than one field, 24.3% are full matches, 72.4% partial, and 3.3% no match; the 31 single-field professors are 90.3% full matches. On average, 61.2% of a multi-field professor's declared fields are in the top three, or 73.1% of the maximum feasible share. Second, the gap is structured: raw top-three rates are 71.0% at one digit, 54.5% at two, and 38.6% at three, and cross-cutting labels such as behavioural economics (11%) and political economy (8%) align poorly. Third, the gap is not mainly about department prestige: top-10 and top-15 departments look like the full sample, and associate professors are only somewhat less aligned, though the difference is sensitive to field controls.

The gap is also not an artefact of a single measurement choice. JEL codes are imperfect: they cover only part of the record, they are assigned by authors and journals rather than by independent coders, and their granularity varies across fields. I discuss these problems in Section 8.5 and show that the main patterns hold under a strict tie-inclusive ranking, an ordinal ranking, and a broad measure that credits a field when its parent code is in the top three. They also hold when the sample is restricted to professors with many JEL-coded papers, when the top-10 and top-15 departments are examined separately, and when the CV-date selection is examined separately. The working-paper analysis in Section 5.2 provides an independent but not decisive

check: it measures a paper's field from the fields of its cited references rather than from its own JEL codes.

I then examine two mechanisms. The first is that economics as a whole has a 'wind': the mix of fields published in the top five journals has shifted over the past two decades, away from international economics and toward macro, labour, and applied microeconomics. Professors whose declared fields are in fields that gained share are significantly more likely to match. That is the mirror image of stickiness: in a rising field the label and the portfolio point the same way, whereas in a declining field the portfolio has moved on while the label remains. The second is that preferences themselves may have changed. If interests are stable and the declared field is a true preference, new work should look like the declared field even when old work does not. I test this with publications after the CV update and with recent working papers. Because a working paper's field is chosen by the author, I do not use its own label; I measure it from the fields of the works it cites. Working papers are about equally close to the declared set and to the published portfolio, which does not point to a rapid move away from the CV but cannot distinguish stable preferences from slow drift.

The paper makes three contributions. First, it frames the field label as a measurement instrument in meta-science rather than as a neutral description of expertise. Second, it provides a portable procedure—declare, map, rank, compare at the same level, and validate against an independent record—for assessing that instrument. Third, it shows how the choice between CV fields and JEL codes changes field-level samples and statistics, with direct implications for meta-analysis and research evaluation.

The rest of the paper describes the data (Section 2), presents the results and robustness checks (Sections 3–4), examines two mechanisms (Section 5), draws out implications for meta-

analysis and research evaluation (Section 6), discusses the findings (Section 7), sets out the methods (Section 8), and concludes (Section 9).

2 Data and Measurement

2.1 Sample

The sampling frame is the 851 tenure-track faculty in the 20 US economics departments ranked highest by IDEAS/RePEc in September 2026. The ranking is the 'all publications, all authors' ranking; the Columbia Business School finance group is excluded because it duplicates Columbia's economics department. I restrict the analysis to faculty whose CV or homepage carries a readable update date, which leaves 362 professors. I then drop Assistant Professors, because their publication portfolios are short and they are less likely to have a stable public field identity; the tenured sample is 273 (228 Professors and 45 Associate Professors), of whom 256 state at least one research field and 212 have JEL-coded publications and can be evaluated.

2.2 Declared fields

The declared fields are taken verbatim from the CV or homepage, with page furniture removed. A field is recorded only if the professor states it. Raw strings are split, normalized, and mapped to JEL. A field that is essentially a JEL category gets that code (Industrial Organization → L; Health Economics → I1); a standard synonym gets the closest category (Labour Economics → J; Behavioural Economics → D9; Political Economy → P); broad labels get the broad field (Economic Theory → D; Econometrics → C). Phrases that fit no JEL category are searched in top-five titles and abstracts and assigned the closest methodological code; the full 314-phrase mapping is in Supplementary Data.

Two features of the mapping matter. The first is the level. A declared field is compared with publication counts at the level of the code it maps to: a one-digit field such as *Labour Economics* is compared with one-digit counts, a two-digit field such as *Health Economics* with two-digit counts, and a three-digit field such as *Climate Change* with three-digit counts. This is the natural interpretation of level matching: a field should be compared at the level at which it is declared. The second is deduplication. When two declared phrases map to the same code (for example, *Behavioural Economics* and *Experience Effects* both map to D9), the code is counted once.

2.3 Publication fields

Publication fields come from RePEc/IDEAS, which records the JEL codes that authors and journals attach to each article. For each professor I count the number of journal articles carrying each one-, two-, and three-digit code up to the CV cut-off year. A paper with several codes contributes to each code, so the counts are not mutually exclusive. The data contain 8,659 articles for the tenured sample; 8,614 of them can be linked to an author list, and 212 professors have at least one JEL-coded article. The median professor has eight JEL-coded articles.

For each level I rank the professor's codes by paper count. A declared field is *in the top three* if its code ranks no lower than third, with ties at the third position counted as inside; this tie-inclusive rule is the main measure. I also report an ordinal ranking that breaks ties by code, and a *broad* measure that counts a declared field as matched if either the field itself or its parent code—the next broader code, two-digit for a three-digit field and one-digit for a two-digit field—is in the professor's top three at the parent's level. The broad measure is useful for two-digit and three-digit fields whose parent is a better summary of the professor's overall profile.

2.4 An example

Consider Daron Acemoglu, who lists nine fields. Political Economy (P) ranks fourth among one-digit fields; Economic Development (O1) and Economic Theory (D) rank second, Technology (O3) first, and Human Capital (J24) and Labour Economics (J) third. Five of his nine fields are in the top three. The example shows the limitation of the measure: a professor with nine fields cannot have all of them in the top three.

3 Results

3.1 The gap

Table 1 reports the main result. Of the 212 evaluable professors, 72 (34.0%) have every declared field in the top three, 131 (61.8%) have at least one but not all, and 9 (4.2%) have none. The full-match rate is concentrated among single-field professors: 28 of 31 (90.3%) are full matches, against 44 of 181 (24.3%) among those declaring two or more fields. For multi-field professors the mean share is 61.2%, or 73.1% of the maximum feasible share $\min(1, 3/k)$; the all-sample mean of 65.4% is pulled up by the single-field group. The average professor has 65.4% of her declared fields in the top three; the median is 66.7%. Under the ordinal ranking the average falls to 60.5%, and under the broad measure it rises to 80.2%. The distribution is bimodal (Fig. [fig:hist]): a large mass at one (professors with a single, well-defined field) and a long tail of partial matches.

[Table 1 near here]

[Figure 1 near here]

Figure 1. Distribution of alignment across the 212 evaluable professors. The vertical axis counts professors; the horizontal axis bins the share of a professor's evaluable declared fields that rank in the top three at the declared JEL level.

3.2 Level and breadth

Raw alignment declines with the granularity of the field (Table 2, Panel A). At the one-digit level, 71.0% of declared fields are in the top three; at the two-digit level, 54.5%; at the three-digit level, 38.6%. The broad measure reverses the gradient (71.0%, 77.3%, 82.8%), because a fine-grained field is more likely to have a top-three parent even when the exact code is not top three. The pattern is intuitive: the finer the claim, the easier it is to find a neighbouring code in which the professor publishes more. The level-specific rates are not directly comparable, because the number of codes differs across levels; the broad measure and the within-level ranks are the appropriate comparisons. The same point applies to the raw rates: a uniform draw from the professor's own codes would match 56.5% at one digit, 38.2% at two, and 36.8% at three, so observed/expected ratios are 1.26, 1.43, and 1.05. At three digits the observed rate is essentially the random benchmark; the one- and two-digit rates are 14.4 and 16.3 points above it. A top-k sensitivity check makes this concrete: at $k = 1,2,3,5,10$ the match rates are 40.4, 57.4, 71.0, 82.0, and 88.2 at one digit; 35.2, 48.5, 54.5, 65.2, and 73.0 at two digits; and 22.1, 31.0, 38.6, 49.0, and 61.4 at three digits. The level gap narrows as k rises but does not disappear.

The number of declared fields is a strong predictor of the raw share (Table 2, Panel B): 90.3% for one field, 80.5% for two, 64.8% for three, 51.8% for four, 44.3% for five, 37.8% for six (the nine groups sum to 212). Part of this is mechanical—a top-three list has only three slots—so the raw gradient should not be read as evidence that professors with long lists are more inaccurate. To see how much is mechanical, I compare the observed share with a within-

professor benchmark that draws a declared field uniformly from the professor's own codes (Table 3). The benchmark is 50.6% overall, against 65.4% observed: declared fields are at least 14.8 points more likely to be in the top three than a random draw from the same portfolio. A draw weighted by the professor's paper counts would give 71.7%, so the observed share lies between the two benchmarks. The excess over the uniform benchmark is 25.0 points at one declared field, 11.8 at three, 7.8 at five, and -5.7 at six; it falls with list length rather than rising. The raw gradient is therefore largely mechanical, and at six fields, where there are ten professors, the declared list is no more aligned than a random draw from the professor's own codes. The 7–9 groups contain only two, three, and one professors and are not interpreted.

[Table 2 near here]

[Table 3 near here]

The within-professor benchmark asks whether a declared field is more central than another code in the same portfolio. A different question is whether the assignment of fields to professors is non-random. To answer it, I reassign the observed declared fields across professors within JEL level by random 2×2 swaps, preserving each professor's number of declared fields and each field's number of declarants; 2,000 draws after 30,000 burn-in swaps give a top-three share of 20.5%, against 65.4% observed ($p < 0.001$). The full-match rate is 34.0% against 6.0%, and the no-match rate 4.2% against 53.6% ($p < 0.001$ for each). Field labels are therefore strongly informative about who works on what. They are not, however, a faithful summary: as the within-portfolio benchmarks show, alignment is well above a uniform draw from the same portfolio but below a draw weighted by output.

3.3 Which fields align?

Table 4 lists fields with at least five evaluable observations. Economic theory and econometric theory are at 100%, health economics at 93%, econometrics at 90%, applied microeconomics at 89%, and labour economics at 86%; behavioural economics (11%) and political economy (8%) are at the bottom. Environmental economics (33%) and economic growth (20%) also align poorly, partly because their papers are coded across Q5/Q4 and O1/O3/O4. Small cells are imprecise—the 100% figures rest on fourteen and seven observations—so the table reports Wilson intervals and the ordering is descriptive.

[Table 4 near here]

The behavioural and political-economy results deserve comment. Both labels are prominent in hiring and in public discussion, but their JEL codes are narrow relative to the work that carries the label. Behavioural economics is coded D9, yet much behavioural work is coded D03 (behavioural microeconomics), D8 (information), or G4 (behavioural finance); political economy is coded P, yet much of it is coded O1 (development), D72 (political processes), or P16 (capitalist institutions). The mismatch is therefore partly a coding convention and partly a real difference between the label and the portfolio. As a leave-out check, dropping the two labels (codes D9 and P) leaves 211 professors and 616 fields: the mean share rises only from 65.4% to 67.7%, the full-match rate from 34.0% to 36.5%, and the no-match rate falls from 4.2% to 3.8%. The overall gap is therefore not produced by these labels alone. I return to this distinction in Section 5.

3.4 Who matches?

Table 5 regresses the share of declared fields in the top three on department rank, title, PhD cohort, productivity, and the number of declared fields. Department rank is never significant:

top-10 professors are 1.1–2.3 percentage points more aligned than the rest, with standard errors of 3–6 points. With 20 clusters these tests have limited power, so I read the null coefficients as 'not detected', not as evidence that rank has no effect. Associate professors are 9–14 points less aligned than full professors, but the estimate is sensitive to field controls. PhD cohort and the number of JEL-coded papers are not significant. The number of declared fields is the strongest correlate: each additional field is associated with a 8.5–9.7 percentage point lower share, and the coefficient is essentially unchanged when one-digit field fixed effects are included.

[Table 5 near here]

4 Robustness

4.1 Selection on CV availability

The tenured sample is selected on having a readable CV or homepage update date. If the 489 faculty without such a date differ systematically, the match rates may not generalize to the full 851. A comparison of the two groups shows that the title distribution is balanced ($\chi^2(2) = 1.18$, $p = 0.56$). The excluded group is older (mean PhD year 1996.7 versus 2004.2, Welch $t = 7.13$, $p < 0.001$; KS $D = 0.23$, $p < 0.001$) and much less likely to state any research field (38% versus 92%), which is mechanical: a CV without a date is often a CV without a research-fields section. The two groups publish similar numbers of JEL-coded papers (9.8 in the excluded group versus 11.2 in the included group, $p = 0.22$), but their publication mix differs: the included group has more mathematical/quantitative (C: 17.5% versus 12.0%, $p = 0.004$) and less macro (E: 7.4% versus 11.5%, $p = 0.001$) and finance (G: 5.1% versus 7.3%, $p = 0.026$).

The selection is therefore real but limited. It affects seniority and the probability of stating a field, not the title mix or productivity. Because the main analysis is conditional on

stating a field, and because field composition is controlled in the regressions, the gap is unlikely to be an artefact of the CV-date restriction. To gauge how much selection on observables could move the result, I reweight the 212 evaluable professors by the inverse probability of having a CV date, estimated in the 851 sample from title, PhD year, and publication-mix shares. The weighted mean share is 64.3% and the weighted full-match rate 33.0%, against 65.4% and 34.0% unweighted; selection on observables therefore moves the headline by about one point. The weights cannot address selection on unobservables. Department rank is also flat: 66.8% in the top 10, 66.1% in the top 15, and 65.4% in the full sample ($p = 0.69$ and $p = 0.82$).

The result is not driven by the lower-ranked departments in the sample, and the rank gradient within the top 20 is flat. This is consistent with the idea that field identity is formed in graduate school and in the profession as a whole rather than in a particular department.

The estimates are also flat across JEL-coverage subsamples (0.646–0.660), which is consistent with the gap being a property of the two records rather than of thin coding.

5 Mechanisms

5.1 The wind: field composition in the top five journals

One hypothesis is that economists form their self-concept when they enter the profession; if the profession's centre of gravity then moves, declared fields may lag behind publication portfolios. The top five shape the profession's agenda (Card and DellaVigna 2013; Heckman and Moktan 2020; Galofré-Vilà 2026), and the field mix of economics has shifted over time (Colander et al. 2004; Milojević 2015). I measure the wind with the field composition of articles published in the top five general-interest journals (AER, QJE, JPE, Econometrica, REStud) between 2006 and 2025. The corpus contains 3,186 top-five articles, of which 1,968 carry at

least one JEL code; I weight each paper by the inverse of its number of one-digit codes so that a paper with three codes contributes one third to each.

Figure 2 shows the largest fields. Macro (E) rises from 12.6% to 15.8%, labour (J) from 8.5% to 10.7%, and regional/urban (R) from 1.5% to 3.1%; international economics (F) falls from 10.2% to 5.2%, and development (O) from 8.3% to 6.8%. The annual series is noisy, but the five-year averages show a shift toward empirical, labour/health/urban work and away from international economics (Angrist and Pischke 2010; Hamermesh 2013).

[Figure 2 near here]

Figure 2. Field composition of top-five journal articles, 2006–2025. Shares are weighted by the inverse of the number of one-digit JEL codes per paper; a paper with three codes contributes one third to each field.

I summarize the wind as the change in a field's share between 2006–2012 and 2019–2025, in percentage points. I then ask whether a declared field's wind predicts whether it is in the professor's top three. Because the wind is a field-level variable, I estimate at the field level with standard errors clustered by professor:

$$\text{Top3}_{if} = \alpha + \beta\,(\text{Wind}_f/10) + \gamma_2 \text{L2}_{if} + \gamma_3 \text{L3}_{if} + \delta\,\text{Top10}_i + \theta\,\text{Associate}_i + \varepsilon_{if}.$$

The estimate is $\widehat{\beta} = 0.233$ (SE 0.104, $p = 0.027$; $N = 650$ field-level observations) per ten-percentage-point increase in a field's share of top-five output—about 2.3 points per one-point increase: a field that gained ten points of share is 23.3 points more likely to be in the professor's top three. At the professor level, the average wind of a professor's declared fields, on the same per-ten-point scale, has a coefficient of 0.337 (SE 0.192, $p = 0.081$). Professors with no match at all have an average wind of -0.10, compared with $+0.003$ for full matches and $+0.004$ for partial matches. The pattern is consistent with a fashion mechanism in which

portfolios and self-descriptions both drift toward fields that are gaining share, but portfolios adjust faster: in a rising field, the label and the portfolio point in the same direction; in a declining field, the portfolio has moved on while the label remains. It does not support a simple 'fixed at entry' story, under which declining fields would match better. This is an association, not a causal estimate: a field's growth raises the publication counts of everyone who works in it, so part of the co-movement is compositional.

5.2 Changing interests: new work and working papers

A competing explanation is preference drift: if current work has moved elsewhere, the gap is not misrepresentation. I use two proxies for new work whose field is not the author's own label.

The first is publications after the CV update date. I match each professor's IDEAS article list to the CV year and keep articles published strictly after it. Only 275 articles, written by 44 professors with at least one post-update article, meet this criterion, because most CVs were updated in 2024–2026. At the professor level, the share of post-update articles whose journal-modal field is in the declared set is 51.0%, compared with 49.3% for pre-update articles (paired t-test $p = 0.71$). The test is underpowered and should be read as descriptive.

The second proxy is recent working papers. Their field is not chosen by a journal editor or a JEL code, so I measure it from the fields of the works they cite: I collect RePEc reference handles, drop working papers and books, map each journal to its one-digit JEL distribution using 4,442 article–code observations, and keep papers with at least ten references and 30% mapped. A paper's field is the modal field of its references.

This measure has a clear interpretation: it captures the intellectual tradition a paper builds on, independently of the author's own label (Milojević 2015; Angrist et al. 2020). If preferences

are stable and declared fields are true preferences, working papers should look like declared fields even when old publications do not. If the gap is driven by drift, working papers should look like the current portfolio and not like the declared fields.

Of the 554 recent working papers I attempted to code, 193 meet the requirement of at least ten references and 30% mapped coverage; restricting to authors in the evaluable sample leaves 186 working papers for 112 professors. The mean coverage is 57.8%. At the working-paper level, the modal citation field is in the declared set for 65.6% of the 186 papers and in the published top three for 66.7%; the corresponding professor-level means are 62.2% and 63.1%. The two benchmarks are close. This is not a discriminating test: new work looks like both the declared set and the current portfolio, so the evidence cannot separate stable preferences from slow drift. The two benchmarks are also not symmetric—the declared set is often broader than the top-three set, and the citation-based field is coarser—so the comparison is descriptive rather than decisive.

The split by match status is mixed: full-match professors' working papers are more often in the published top three (64.7%) than in the declared set (53.9%), while partial matches show the reverse (62.4% vs 67.9%; 43 and 67 professors). The full-match gap is partly mechanical—the declared set is a subset of the top three—and the cells are small. I therefore treat the test as inconclusive.

6 Implications for meta-analysis and research evaluation

The results so far describe a gap between two records. For a survey journal, the more important question is what the gap does to the infrastructure of cumulative research. Field labels are not only descriptions; they are sampling frames. A meta-analysis of a literature, a systematic review, a department's field profile, or a bibliometric ranking all begin by deciding which

scholars or papers belong to a field. Meta-analysis has developed sophisticated tools for combining estimates (Stanley and Doucouliagos 2012), but it typically takes the classification of studies as given. The two records support different decisions, and they are not nested.

Consider three uses.

First, meta-analysis. A meta-analyst who searches by JEL code and one who recruits authors by self-declared field will not see the same population. The difference is largest where labels are cross-cutting. Behavioural economics is the clearest case: 18 evaluable professors declare it, but only 11% of those declarations are in the professor's top three JEL codes; political economy has 13 declarations and 8%. A JEL-code search restricted to D9 or P would miss most of the work that self-identified behavioural or political economists publish. Conversely, a CV-based author search would include scholars whose codes lie in D, D03, G4, O1, D72, or P16. The two sampling frames therefore produce different literatures, and the choice between them is not a coding detail. If the outcome of the meta-analysis is field-specific, the choice changes the estimand.

Second, research evaluation. Departments, funders, and rankings increasingly use field labels to measure specialization, diversity, and fit. A CV-based field count measures how scholars present themselves; a JEL-based count measures where papers are recorded. The first is broader and more aspirational, the second narrower and more backward-looking. Using one as if it were the other will overstate the presence of fashionable or cross-cutting labels and understate the presence of fields whose papers are coded under sibling categories. The direction of the bias is predictable: it is largest for labels that span several codes and smallest for fields with a dedicated code and a clear canon. This is not an argument against either measure; it is an argument for reporting both and for treating their divergence as information.

Third, field-level statistics. Claims that a field is growing, declining, or becoming more specialized depend on the classification used. A field can grow in CV labels without growing in papers, or grow in papers without growing in labels. The wind results in Section 5.1 show that the two records move together only imperfectly. A time series that uses one record will attribute to the field a change that belongs to the other.

What should applied work do? Three practices follow. (i) Report the classification instrument: whether a field is measured from CVs, JEL codes, journal categories, or text. (ii) Validate the instrument where possible, using a second record or a hand-coded audit. (iii) Report both records when the question concerns the boundary of a field, and treat the gap as a quantity to be estimated rather than a nuisance to be averaged away.

These implications are not confined to economics. Medicine, education, and other fields also use self-reported specialties alongside procedure or publication records. The framework—declare, map, rank, compare at the same level, and validate against an independent record—travels to any discipline with a usable classification of publications. The substantive finding is likely to generalize: self-reported fields are broader and more identity-laden than the record, and the gap is largest where labels are socially salient or cross-cutting.

A final implication concerns the interpretation of the gap itself. It is tempting to read the gap as error in the CV: scholars say they work on something they do not publish. That reading is too simple. A CV field is a claim about identity, audience, and aspiration; a JEL code is a trace of what was published, where, and with whom. The two records answer different questions. The mistake is not that one is wrong; it is that they are treated as substitutes.

7 Discussion

The results describe a profession in which the field label and the publication record are correlated but far from identical. Three interpretations are consistent with the patterns.

The first is identity. Self-categorization theory holds that people define themselves partly by the groups they belong to and the labels those groups carry (Turner et al. 1987; Stryker 1980); self-perception theory and cognitive dissonance make a related point (Bem 1972; Festinger 1957). A research field is such a group, with journals, seminars, a canon, and a reputation. Declaring a field is a claim of membership, and the claim need not be proportional to output. This explains why the gap is largest for socially salient, cross-cutting labels and smallest for fields with a clear canon and a dedicated JEL code.

The second is field fashion. The top five journals' mix has moved toward macro, labour, and urban/regional work and away from international economics. A professor trained in the 1990s may still describe herself with the field that was central then, even if her recent papers have followed the journals: the label is sticky while the portfolio moves. The positive wind coefficient is its mirror image: in fields that gained share, label and portfolio are aligned, so match is higher.

The third is strategic signalling. Field labels position a scholar for hiring, promotion, and refereeing (Goffman 1959), and a broader label signals openness to a range of work. This is especially relevant for junior faculty, although my tenured sample shows only a modest associate–full difference.

What does this mean for bibliometrics? Field classifications measure specialization, diversity, and fit, and citation-based measures have well-known limits (Hamermesh 2018; Angrist et al. 2020). My results caution against treating a self-reported field as a measure of

output. A JEL-based measure captures the portfolio; a CV field captures identity. Both are useful, but they answer different questions.

7.1 Limitations

Several limitations remain. JEL codes are an imperfect record—coverage is incomplete, assignment is not independent, and granularity varies—so the estimates are declared-versus-recorded gaps, not measures of true interests. The phrase-to-code mapping involves judgement; the rule-based audit agrees at the one-digit level but less at exact codes (Table 6), and a 50-professor audit sheet is provided for a second coder. JEL codes are not validated against article content; this is the main measurement gap. The sample is tenured top-20 faculty, so external validity is limited. The wind corpus is small and noisy, the post-CV test is underpowered, and the working-paper measure is a citation proxy.

8 Methods

8.1 Data sources

Faculty lists and titles are from the departments' official directories. Research fields are from CVs and personal homepages, extracted by hand and checked against the source. Publication records and JEL codes are from RePEc/IDEAS and EconPapers. Department ranks are the IDEAS/RePEc 'all publications, all authors' ranking for September 2026. The JEL classification follows the 2026 AEA system (American Economic Association 2026). Working-paper lists and reference lists are from IDEAS author and paper pages (RePEc/IDEAS 2026).

8.2 Match measure

For professor i, level ℓ, and declared field f mapped to code c at level ℓ, let n_{ic} be the number of papers carrying code c and r_{ic} its rank among all codes at level ℓ (ties share the

minimum rank). The field is in the top three if $r_{ic} \leq 3$. The professor-level share is the mean of this indicator over evaluable declared fields. A professor is a full match if the share is one, a partial match if it is between zero and one, and a no match if it is zero. The broad measure replaces $r_{ic} \leq 3$ with $r_{ic} \leq 3$ or $r_{i,\text{parent}(c)} \leq 3$, where parent($c$) is the next broader code (the two-digit parent of a three-digit code, or the one-digit parent of a two-digit code).

The null benchmark draws a declared field from the professor's own portfolio. Let $C_{i\ell}$ be the set of codes with positive paper counts at level ℓ, $m_{i\ell} = |C_{i\ell}|$, and $T_{i\ell}$ the subset with tie-inclusive rank at most three. A field drawn uniformly from $C_{i\ell}$ matches with probability $|T_{i\ell}|/m_{i\ell}$; a field drawn with probability proportional to paper counts matches with probability $\sum_{c\in T_{i\ell}} n_{ic} / \sum_{c\in C_{i\ell}} n_{ic}$. I average each expectation over the same declared fields as the observed share.

The permutation benchmark reassigns the observed fields across professors within level by random 2×2 swaps, preserving each professor's number of declared fields and each field's number of declarants; it uses 2,000 draws after 30,000 burn-in swaps. The two benchmarks answer different questions: the within-professor benchmark compares a declared field with other codes in the same portfolio, while the permutation benchmark compares the observed person–field matching with a random matching that preserves field popularity.

8.3 Field wind

For each one-digit field f and year t, let s_{ft} be the share of top-five JEL codes in f, weighted by the inverse of the number of one-digit codes per paper. The wind is $W_f = \bar{s}_{f,2019-2025} - \bar{s}_{f,2006-2012}$ in percentage points. In the regression I divide W_f by 10, so β is the

effect of a ten-percentage-point increase; the equation is estimated by ordinary least squares with standard errors clustered by professor.

8.4 Working-paper field

For working paper j, let R_j be the set of references with a RePEc journal handle. Each reference r is mapped to a one-digit distribution d_r using the journal's JEL distribution in the 4,442 JEL-coded article–code observations of the corpus. The working paper's field distribution is the average of d_r over $r \in R_j$ with a mapped journal; the modal field is the working paper's field. Working papers with fewer than ten references or less than 30% coverage are dropped.

8.5 Measurement error in JEL codes

JEL codes are not produced by an independent classification of article content. Authors select them, journals request or impose them, and databases record what they receive. Coverage is incomplete (about 45% of articles), and not random: it varies with vintage, journal, and the length of a scholar's record. Codes can be strategic, and conventions change; the 2026 revision renamed categories and moved concepts between codes, and adjacent codes often describe the same work. Of the 273 professors, 17 state no field and 44 state a field but have no coded article, so 61 are not evaluable.

These features create attenuation, misclassification, and endogeneity. If a field's papers are uncoded, its count is too low; if papers are coded under a sibling category—behavioural economics under D03 rather than D9, political economy under O1 or D72 rather than P—a true match can look like a mismatch; and if coding responds to fashion or evaluation incentives, the error is correlated with the gap itself.

Several choices reduce these threats. I compare fields at the level at which they are declared; I report the tie-inclusive rank, an ordinal rank, and a broad parent-code measure; the first two give the same professor-level ordering and overall gap, while the broad measure reverses the level gradient, so I use the strict measure for levels and the broad measure as a robustness check. The comparison is within professor, so coding conventions common to all of a professor's papers are differenced out. Results are stable across JEL-coverage and rank subsamples. The field-specific patterns match known coding conventions: behavioural economics and political economy, the lowest-matching labels, are precisely those most often coded under sibling categories. The working-paper measure does not use the article's own JEL codes.

To gauge method variance, I re-coded the 164 fields of the 50-professor audit sample with an independent keyword rule that uses only the official JEL names (Table 6). The rule covers 151 fields (92.1%). At the one-digit level it agrees with the hand mapping on 97.4% of fields (Cohen's kappa 0.97); exact code agreement is 80.8%. Re-coding the 151 fields with the rule's finer codes lowers the mean share from 62.6% to 56.1% (-6.5 points). The family-level mapping is therefore robust, while the exact-code level of the gap is sensitive to fine-grained code choice. This is a method-variance check, not a second human coder.

[Table 6 near here]

What remains is residual ambiguity: a mismatch can mean that the self-description is broader than the record, or that papers are coded under a different label. The data cannot fully separate the two. The object is the gap between two public records—the CV field and the coded article—both used in evaluation; that gap is real even when its proximate cause is a coding convention. The interpretation is 'declared versus recorded', not 'true interest versus true output'.

9 Conclusion

The central lesson of this paper is not that economists misdescribe themselves. It is that self-description and bibliographic records measure different things. Among the 181 evaluable professors who declare more than one field, 24.3% have a publication portfolio that fully matches the fields on the CV, 72.4% match partially, and 3.3% have no match; the 31 single-field professors are 90.3% full matches. Against a uniform draw from each professor's own codes, the observed share is 14.8 points higher; against a draw weighted by her output it is 6.3 points lower; against a random reassignment of fields across professors it is 45 points higher (20.5%). The labels are informative about who works on what, but they are not a faithful summary of the portfolio. Under the strict top-three measure, the raw gap is larger at finer levels, in cross-cutting fields, and for professors who claim many fields. Department prestige does not account for it; seniority is associated with a modest, control-sensitive gap. It is consistent with sticky self-concepts, with a profession whose centre of gravity has moved, and with the strategic use of field labels.

This distinction matters beyond economics: every field that asks scholars to describe their expertise, and every system that records their output, faces the same substitution problem. The framework—declare, map, rank, compare at the same level, and validate against an independent record—can be applied to medicine, education, political science, or sociology. For research evaluation, the implication is not that one measure should replace the other. A CV field measures identity and audience; a JEL-based field measures portfolio composition. Using the first as if it were the second overstates fit; using the second as if it were the first misses the intellectual project. The two should be reported together, and their divergence treated as information rather than error. For meta-science, the lesson is that classification is part of the measurement model,

not a preliminary step: the choice of field label changes who is in the sample and what the sample can support. Future work could follow scholars over time and test whether the gap responds to incentives.

Ethics statement

Not applicable. The study uses publicly available CVs, homepages, and bibliographic records; no human participants were involved.

Conflict of interest

The author declares no conflict of interest.

Data availability

The replication package (analysis files, field mapping table, and code) is available from the corresponding author and will be deposited in a public repository upon acceptance. The underlying faculty data are derived from public CVs, homepages, and RePEc/IDEAS records.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies

During the preparation of this work the author used an AI-assisted writing tool for language editing and code support. The author reviewed and edited the content and takes full responsibility for the content of the publication.

References

Akerlof, G. A., and R. E. Kranton. 2000. “Economics and Identity.” Quarterly Journal of Economics 115 (3): 715–753.

American Economic Association. 2026. “JEL Classification System / EconLit Subject Descriptors.” https://www.aeaweb.org/econlit/jelCodes.php (accessed 22 October 2026).

Angrist, J., P. Azoulay, G. Ellison, R. Hill, and S. F. Lu. 2020. “Inside Job or Deep Impact? Extramural Citations and the Influence of Economic Scholarship.” Journal of Economic Literature 58 (1): 3–52.

Angrist, J. D., and J.-S. Pischke. 2010. “The Credibility Revolution in Empirical Economics: How Better Research Design Is Taking the Con out of Econometrics.” Journal of Economic Perspectives 24 (2): 3–30.

Bem, D. J. 1972. “Self-Perception Theory.” Advances in Experimental Social Psychology 6: 1–62.

Brodeur, A., N. Cook, and A. Heyes. 2020. “Methods Matter: P-Hacking and Publication Bias in Causal Analysis in Economics.” American Economic Review 110 (11): 3634–3660.

Card, D., and S. DellaVigna. 2013. “Nine Facts about Top Journals in Economics.” Journal of Economic Literature 51 (1): 144–161.

Christensen, G., and E. Miguel. 2018. “Transparency, Reproducibility, and the Credibility of Economics Research.” Journal of Economic Literature 56 (3): 920–980.

Colander, D. 2005. “The Making of an Economist Redux.” Journal of Economic Perspectives 19 (1): 175–198.

Colander, D., R. P. F. Holt, and J. B. Rosser. 2004. The Changing Face of Economics: Conversations with Cutting Edge Economists. University of Michigan Press.

Festinger, L. 1957. A Theory of Cognitive D*issonance*. Stanford University Press.

Galofré-Vilà, G. 2026. “Network Analysis of ‘Top-Five’ Economics Journals.” Journal of Comparative Economics 54 (2): 621–634.

Goffman, E. 1959. The Presentation of Self in Everyday L*ife*. Doubleday.

Hamermesh, D. S. 2013. “Six Decades of Top Economics Publishing: Who and How?” Journal of Economic Literature 51 (1): 162–172.

Hamermesh, D. S. 2018. “Citations in Economics: Measurement, Uses, and Impacts.” Journal of Economic Literature 56 (1): 115–156.

Heckman, J. J., and S. Moktan. 2020. “Publishing and Promotion in Economics: The Tyranny of the Top Five.” Journal of Economic Literature 58 (2): 419–470.

Klamer, A., and D. Colander. 1990. The Making of an E*conomist*. Westview Press.

Kuhn, T. S. 1962. The Structure of Scientific R*evolutions*. University of Chicago Press.

Milojević, S. 2015. “Quantifying the Cognitive Extent of Science.” Journal of Informetrics 9 (4): 962–973.

RePEc/IDEAS. 2026. “RePEc Author Service and IDEAS Bibliographic Database.” https://ideas.repec.org (accessed 22 October 2026).

Stanley, T. D., and H. Doucouliagos. 2012. Meta-Regression Analysis in Economics and B*usiness*. Routledge.

Stryker, S. 1980. Symbolic Interactionism: A Social Structural V*ersion*. Benjamin Cummings.

Turner, J. C., M. A. Hogg, P. J. Oakes, S. D. Reicher, and M. S. Wetherell. 1987. Rediscovering the Social Group: A Self-Categorization T*heory*. Blackwell.